



'Find My Friends'

application. This design cannot be called skeuomorphic, because there is no real world analogue to the functionality of this application. In fact, the Apple design “style” isn’t really skeuomorphic, the correct term for this kind of design would be kitsch – the inspiration for these designs is primarily nostalgia.

So is skeuomorphic design outdated? Is it bad design? The answers to these questions are inconclusive. There’s a difference between bad taste and bad design. The purpose served by the aesthetics of a design is to create a powerful visual metaphor. Take the example of the File Manager app that most Android users are familiar with. There’s a reason the icon is shaped like a file cabinet or a folder. It’s a non verbal message to the users that efficiently and wordlessly communicates the functionality of the product to them. So when used as visual metaphors, skeuomorphs are pretty useful. However, take the case of the tacky and over used leather textures on iOS, since they serve only ornamental purposes, they are an example of bad taste (not bad design). Also, we cannot deny that despite the criticisms leveled against their designs, Apple successfully sold their products, and built a signature style that lasted many years. In the age of personal computers and smartphones, skeuomorphic design was necessary. Skeuomorphs